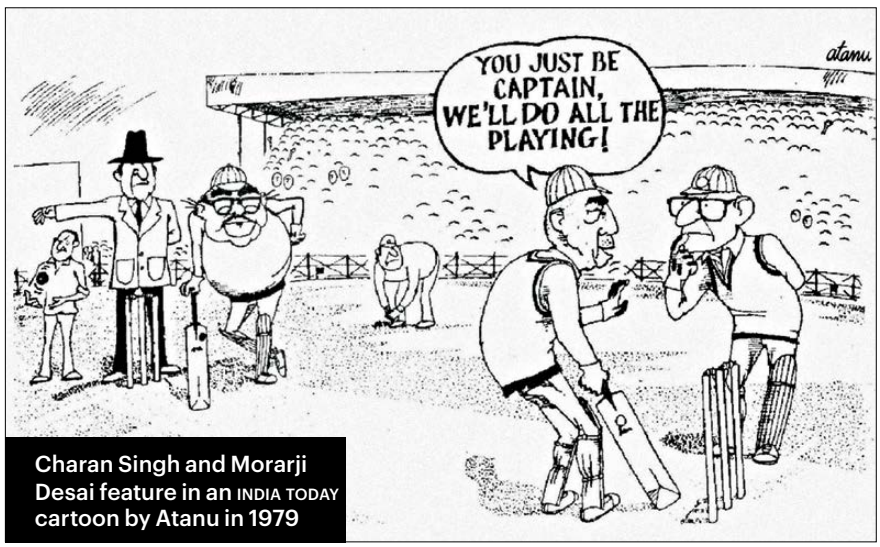
In hindsight, the Janata government's brief career reads like the chronicle of a death foretold. But before it began to collapse under the weight of its own contradictions, the coalition was bound by the seemingly robust glue of a righteous democratic triumph and a shared veneration for the spartan but frail Jayaprakash Narayan.

In fact, the seeds of failure were already germinating at the moment of the Janata's victory in March 1977, in the vaunting ambitions of its many colourful leaders. At the time, feathers were smoothed by the remarkable spectacle. The party was also riven by disagreement over calls for members of the erstwhile Jan Sangh to disassociate themselves from the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh.

"The only truthful action of the Janata government has been to prematurely announce JP's death," said Arun Shourie on Mar. 23, 1979

On March 23, 1979, a somewhat farcical—and all too portentous—scandal erupted, when All India Radio mistakenly announced JP's death. While Parliament was also adjourned in response to this (fake) news, the PM pointedly declined to declare national mourning. "The only truthful action of the Janata government so far," thundered Arun Shourie, who was quoted in these pages, "has been to prematurely announce [JP's] death. They killed his promises and now they are bent on killing him as well."

In the event, Morarji Desai's government, reduced by defections and resignations, would last only till July 15. The mortally ill Jayaprakash Narayan briefly outlived this disappointment, before dying of kidney failure on October 8. ■



Charan Singh and Morarji Desai feature in an INDIA TODAY cartoon by Atanu in 1979

stratagem of leaving the choice of prime minister to JP and another Gandhian elder, Acharya Kripalani. Their choice of Morarji Desai was a bitter pill for some, but earlier in the day, the wheelchair-bound JP had led the Janata MPs in an oath of unity at Raj Ghat.

While JP's moral authority papered over the cracks of ideological difference and personal dislike for a while, his influence soon faded along with his health. The mercurial Raj Narain was the first to fall out with his colleagues, but factional feuds between the PM and his two Deputy PMs Jagjivan Ram and Charan Singh were soon a public

JP'S MORAL AUTHORITY PAPERED OVER THE CRACKS OF IDEOLOGICAL DIFFERENCES, BUT HIS INFLUENCE FADED ALONG WITH HIS HEALTH. SOON, THE FEUDS WITHIN JANATA WERE A PUBLIC SPECTACLE



Janata's Disaster
July 16-31, 1979

"Desai's brand of casual arrogance, cultivated disdain and crude evasiveness wore thin in a moment of national crisis. It was typical of the faddist, unrelenting Desai, who, for over 15 years, had nurtured the singular obsession of getting to the prime minister's chair in South Block. Having achieved his life's ambition, he has alienated himself from the Cabinet, the party, the administration and the people."